is running at around 7%, outstripping China, and the experts who study such matters now confidently predict that the total size of the Indian economy will surpass the total of the German and Japanese economies combined by the end of 2019.

Such observations may seem out of place in the autobiography of a mere cricketer but, for me, this extraordinary progress in the last 25 years could hardly be more relevant.

As India has grown and developed beyond anyone's imagination, so has its favourite sport grown and developed beyond anyone's imagination, with the result that India is now the most influential power in world cricket, the leading Indian players are recognised as the superstars of the game, and international cricketers, far from dreading every visit to the subcontinent, now crave nothing more than an invitation to play in India.

In cricket, the most obvious exhibition of this growth, the gleaming, towering skyscraper on the landscape of our sport, is the Indian Premier League, which launched its ninth season in April 2016.

I am very fortunate to be playing during this era, to have been able to enjoy experiences and accept opportunities that were once inconceivable for a boy from Bela-Bela.

My first visit to India with the Proteas, back in 2006, stands clear in my memory. Albie Morkel and I were two excited youngsters on tour and, wherever we happened to be, we grabbed every opportunity to get out of the hotel and see as much of the country as possible. Filming everything on camcorders, we travelled by tuk-tuk (taxis amounting to a covered seat attached to the back of a motorbike), weaving in and out of the traffic amid the constant chorus of hooters; it was hard to understand how almost everyone seemed to remain so calm.

If someone had stopped us on one of these trips, and told us we would both soon be earning several tens of millions of rupees playing in India for two months each year, we would have said they were mad.

The concept of the IPL was simple: assemble the best Twenty20 players